Everyday life

A conversational idiom workbook: 13 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

In this workbook

1. **by all means**: A polite way to say 'yes, of course, please do'.
2. **clear up (weather)**: When the weather clears up, clouds, rain or fog go away and it gets brighter.
3. **come across**: To find or meet something by chance.
4. **cut down on**: To use or do less of something, usually to be healthier or save money.
5. **gathering dust**: If something is gathering dust, nobody uses it any more.
6. **get rid of**: To throw away or remove something you do not want or need.
7. **keep (someone) posted**: To give someone new information regularly as a situation changes.
8. **on the receiving end of**: The person who gets something, often something unpleasant.
9. **out of sight, out of mind**: If you don't see something, you stop thinking about it.
10. **put (someone) off**: To make someone not want to do something or not like something.
11. **to say nothing of**: Used to add one more thing that is even more extreme than the thing you just mentioned.
12. **take advantage of**: To make good use of a chance or situation. With a person, it means to treat them unfairly.
13. **up for grabs**: Available for anyone to take or win.

How to use it: read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

by all means

Expression · Level B2 · Neutral

A polite way to say 'yes, of course, please do'.

Tip: Use it to give someone permission or to welcome a request, often followed by a command ("By all means, sit down"); don't use it to agree with an opinion.

Olena: Do you mind if I open the window? It's a bit stuffy in here.

Kofi: By all means. I was thinking the same thing.

Olena: Thanks. Oh, and is anyone sitting in this chair?

Kofi: No, it's free. My sister is joining us later, but she can sit next to me.

Olena: Great. I'll put my bag here, then.

1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "by all means" mean?

- ○ A. Yes, I agree with your opinion
- ○ B. Yes, of course, go ahead
- ○ C. I'd prefer you didn't, but it's fine
- ○ D. I'm not sure, but I suppose so

2. Fill the gap

If you'd like to look around the flat before you decide, _____, take as much time as you need.

3. Choose the best reply

Amira: *Would it be okay if I borrowed your charger for a few minutes?*

- ○ A. By all means, I completely agree with you.
- ○ B. By all means, I have never borrowed one.
- ○ C. By all means, it's right there on the desk.

4. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you helped a neighbour, a colleague or a friend with something they asked for.

_____

_____

_____

clear up (weather)

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Casual

When the weather clears up, clouds, rain or fog go away and it gets brighter.

Tip: Use it with 'it' or a weather word as the subject (the sky, the fog, the rain); it describes weather getting better, and you can add 'by' + a time to say when.

Kofi: Is the ferry still running? I can barely see the water this morning.

Amira: Yes, but the fog is thick. They said it might not leave until ten.

Kofi: That's a shame. I wanted to get to the island before the crowds.

Amira: Let's grab a coffee first. It usually starts to clear up around nine here.

Kofi: Good idea. If it does, we can still catch the second boat.

5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "clear up" mean?

- ○ A. People tidy the area near the harbour
- ○ B. The ferry company explains the delay
- ○ C. The fog goes away and the weather gets brighter
- ○ D. The temperature drops quickly

6. Fill the gap

The rain was heavy all morning, but it finally _____ in the afternoon, so we went for a walk.

7. Choose the best reply

Ken: *I'm worried about the picnic. It's been pouring since breakfast.*

- ○ A. Don't worry, I'll clear up the picnic before noon.
- ○ B. Don't worry, the picnic will clear up the rain by noon.
- ○ C. Don't worry, the forecast says it'll clear up by noon.

8. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time bad weather changed your plans. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

come across

Phrasal verb · Level B1 · Neutral

To find or meet something by chance.

Tip: Use 'come across' + a thing or person you find unexpectedly (I came across it); don't use it for something you were looking for on purpose, and don't confuse it with 'come across as' (to seem).

Amira: Did you ever find that recipe your grandmother used to make?

Kofi: Yes! I came across it yesterday in a box of old books.

Amira: Really? I thought you'd lost it years ago.

Kofi: So did I. I was only looking for a charger.

Amira: That's lucky. Are you going to cook it this weekend?

9. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'came across' mean?

- ○ A. Bought in a shop
- ○ B. Borrowed from someone
- ○ C. Searched for carefully
- ○ D. Found by chance

10. Fill the gap

While Diego was tidying the garage, he _____ his old bicycle helmet.

11. Choose the best reply

Olena: *Where did you get that old map of the city?*

- ○ A. I came across it in a second-hand shop last week.
- ○ B. I came across it to the shop last week.
- ○ C. I came across my friend's map for a plan.

12. Your turn: speak

Tell me about something interesting you found unexpectedly. What was it, and what did you do with it?

cut down on

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To use or do less of something, usually to be healthier or save money.

Tip: Use it with 'on' plus the thing you reduce (cut down on coffee, cut down on spending); it's a gradual reduction, not stopping completely.

Amira: Are you getting another coffee? That's your third today.

Ken: I know, I know. I can't sleep properly lately.

Amira: Maybe you should cut down on caffeine in the afternoon.

Ken: Yeah, you're right. Maybe I'll switch to water after lunch.

Amira: Try it for a week and see if you sleep better.

Ken: Okay, deal. This is my last one for today.

13. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does cut down on mean?

- ○ A. Buy something at a cheaper price
- ○ B. Stop completely and never have it again
- ○ C. Cut something into smaller pieces
- ○ D. Use less of something

14. Fill the gap

My phone bill is too high, so I need to _____ data when I'm away from Wi-Fi.

15. Choose the best reply

Olena: *I spend way too much money on takeaway food.*

- ○ A. Maybe you could cut down on it and cook at home more often.
- ○ B. Maybe you could cut down it on and cook at home more often.
- ○ C. Maybe you could cut it down on and cook at home more often.

16. Your turn: speak

Is there anything you have tried to use or do less of recently? Tell me about it.

gathering dust

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

If something is gathering dust, nobody uses it any more.

Tip: Use it with 'be' or 'sit' + 'gathering dust' (is/has been gathering dust) for things like gadgets, equipment or ideas that are no longer used; it's usually a little critical or regretful.

Amira: Are you still using that treadmill in the spare room?

Diego: Honestly, no. I bought it in January, and it's been gathering dust since March.

Amira: That's a shame. My cousin is looking for one, actually.

Diego: Really? Tell them to come and get it. It's free if they can carry it.

Amira: I'll pass it on. It's better than leaving it there.

17. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "gathering dust" mean?

- ○ A. Nobody is using it any more
- ○ B. It is broken and needs repairs
- ○ C. It is too expensive to keep
- ○ D. It is being cleaned regularly

18. Fill the gap

I signed up for three online courses last year, but they're all just _____ on my laptop now.

19. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *Did you ever finish decorating the study with all those shelves you bought?*

- ○ A. No, the shelves were so dusty that I had to throw them away.
- ○ B. Not yet. Most of the boxes are still in the hall, gathering dust.
- ○ C. Yes, I'm gathering dust every weekend to make it look nice.

20. Your turn: speak

Is there something you bought that you hardly ever use? Tell me about it.

_____

_____

_____

get rid of

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To throw away or remove something you do not want or need.

Tip: Use it with an object: get rid of + something (get rid of the sofa); the object can go between nothing, and you can't say 'get rid' alone. Past form: got rid of.

Amira: Have you finished packing for the move?

Ken: Not even close. My flat is full of stuff I never use.

Amira: Same thing happened to me last year. Are you keeping the big bookshelf?

Ken: No, it's too heavy. I'm going to get rid of it this weekend.

Amira: My cousin is looking for one. I can ask if she wants it.

Ken: That would be great. It's better than paying someone to take it away.

21. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "get rid of" mean?

- ○ A. To move something heavy from one room to another
- ○ B. To repair something that is broken so it works again
- ○ C. To buy something new to replace an old thing
- ○ D. To stop using something because you do not want or need it any more

22. Fill the gap

My phone is full, so I need to _____ some of my old photos.

23. Choose the best reply

Olena: *Your desk looks so messy. How do you find anything on it?*

- ○ A. I know. I really should get rid all these old papers.
- ○ B. I know. I really should get rid from these old papers.
- ○ C. I know. I really should get rid of all these old papers.

24. Your turn: speak

Is there something you got rid of recently? Tell me about it and why you did it.

keep (someone) posted

Idiom | Level B1 | Casual

To give someone new information regularly as a situation changes.

Tip: Use the pattern 'keep + person + posted' (keep me posted, keep them posted); it's often said as a friendly request when someone is waiting for news, and it's not used for one-off facts, so don't say 'keep me posted' when you only want a single answer.

Olena: My flight's delayed again. They're saying another hour, maybe two.

Kofi: Ugh, that's annoying. I was going to pick you up at six.

Olena: Don't leave yet. I'll check the board every so often.

Kofi: Okay, keep me posted and I'll head to the airport when you know more.

Olena: Will do. I'll text you as soon as they confirm a new time.

25. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "keep me posted" mean?

- ○ A. Mail me a letter at the airport
- ○ B. Send me updates as things change
- ○ C. Wait for me until the flight lands
- ○ D. Tell me the final time only once

26. Fill the gap

The builders haven't finished the kitchen yet, so I'll _____ about when we can move back in.

27. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I'm waiting to hear if my sister's surgery went well, but it could take a few hours.*

- ○ A. Oh, I'll post it for you as soon as I can.
- ○ B. Oh, you should keep posted the hospital about it.
- ○ C. Oh, I hope it goes smoothly. Keep me posted, okay?

28. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you were waiting for important news. How did you stay in touch with other people about it?

on the receiving end of

Expression | Level B2 | Neutral

The person who gets something, often something unpleasant.

Tip: Use it with 'be' and a noun or '-ing' phrase: 'on the receiving end of a complaint / of someone's anger'. It usually describes something negative, so avoid it for good news unless you are joking.

Amira: You look tired. Was it a rough shift at the shop?

Diego: Honestly, yes. A customer was furious about a late delivery, and I was on the receiving end of it for twenty minutes.

Amira: Oh no. Was it even your fault?

Diego: Not at all. The courier lost the parcel, but I was the only person standing there.

Amira: That's so unfair. Let's get some food, and you can tell me everything.

29. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "on the receiving end of" mean?

- ○ A. The person who was waiting at the front of the queue
- ○ B. The person who was responsible for the mistake
- ○ C. The person who had to deal with someone's anger
- ○ D. The person who delivered the parcel

30. Fill the gap

Nobody likes being _____ constant criticism from their manager.

31. Choose the best reply

Ken: *My neighbour's dog barked all night, so I left a note, and now he won't even say hello.*

- ○ A. Oh dear. I hope the dog is on the receiving end of a long walk and a good dinner tonight.
- ○ B. Oh dear. You should receive the end of the note and then speak to him.
- ○ C. Oh dear. It's not nice to be on the receiving end of a cold shoulder, even when you were polite.

32. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you had to deal with someone else's bad mood or complaint. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

out of sight, out of mind

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

If you don't see something, you stop thinking about it.

Tip: Say it as a complete comment after something happens, often with a slightly humorous or resigned tone; it is a fixed phrase, so don't change the word order.

Olena: Did you finish the gym membership cancellation yet?

Kofi: No, I keep forgetting. I only remember when I'm charged.

Olena: Why don't you put the card in your bag instead of the kitchen drawer?

Kofi: Because I never look in my bag. The card is in the drawer, but it's out of sight, out of mind.

Olena: Then set a reminder on your phone. Do it today!

Kofi: Good idea. I'll do it right now.

33. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "out of sight, out of mind" mean?

- ○ A. When you can't see well, you can't think clearly.
- ○ B. When something is hidden, you become worried about it.
- ○ C. When you leave a place, you feel calmer.
- ○ D. When something is not in front of you, you forget about it.

34. Fill the gap

I put the bills in a folder, and now I never think about them. It's really _____ !

35. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I moved the biscuits to the top shelf, and I haven't wanted one all week.*

- ○ A. Out of sight, out of mind, right?
- ○ B. That's a shame. You should keep them where you can see them out of sight.
- ○ C. Yes, I always keep my biscuits out of mind and out of sight, too.

36. Your turn: speak

Is there something you do to avoid distractions or temptations when you want to focus?

_____

_____

_____

put (someone) off

Phrasal verb | Level B2 | Neutral

To make someone not want to do something or not like something.

Tip: Use 'put someone off' (or 'put someone off something/doing something') for things that kill your interest; the person goes in the middle: 'put me off', not 'put off me'. Don't confuse it with 'put off' meaning 'postpone'.

Amira: Are you still thinking about joining the gym on Main Street?

Diego: Not really. I went to look around yesterday, and the changing rooms were filthy.

Amira: Oh no. That's disappointing, the prices are really good.

Diego: I know, but that completely put me off. I'd rather pay a bit more somewhere clean.

Amira: Fair enough. There's a newer one near the station, if you want to check it out.

37. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "put me off" mean?

- ○ A. Made me delay joining the gym until later
- ○ B. Made me feel physically tired
- ○ C. Made me leave the gym immediately
- ○ D. Made me not want to join the gym

38. Fill the gap

I was excited about the hiking trip, but the terrible weather forecast really _____.

39. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *Have you tried the new café by the office? I heard the coffee is great.*

- ○ A. Not yet. The reviews about slow service put me off a bit.
- ○ B. Not yet. I put the café off because of the slow service.
- ○ C. Not yet. The reviews about slow service put off me a bit.

40. Your turn: speak

Is there a food, a place or an activity you used to like but don't enjoy anymore? What changed?

_____

_____

_____

to say nothing of

Expression · Level B2 · Neutral

Used to add one more thing that is even more extreme than the thing you just mentioned.

Tip: Use it after a complaint or problem to add a bigger one, followed by a noun phrase or -ing form (to say nothing of the cost / of paying for parking); don't use it for good news that isn't extreme.

Olena: Are you going to take the car into the city for the concert on Saturday?

Kofi: I'd rather not. The traffic will be terrible, to say nothing of finding somewhere to park.

Olena: True. Last time I spent forty minutes just looking for a space.

Kofi: Exactly. The train is slower, but at least it's cheap.

Olena: Okay, let's take the train. I'll check the times tonight.

41. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "to say nothing of" mean?

- ○ A. except for
- ○ B. so I don't want to talk about it
- ○ C. which is the opposite of what I just said
- ○ D. and also, which is an even bigger problem

42. Fill the gap

Working from the café was a bad idea. The Wi-Fi kept dropping, _____ the constant noise from the coffee machine.

43. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I'm not moving into that flat. The rent is far too high, ...*

- ○ A. to say nothing of the long journey to work every day.
- ○ B. to say nothing, so please don't ask me about it.
- ○ C. to say nothing of how cheap and comfortable it is.

44. Your turn: speak

Describe a trip or journey that was more difficult than you expected. What went wrong?

_____

_____

_____

take advantage of

Expression · Level B1 · Neutral

To make good use of a chance or situation. With a person, it means to treat them unfairly.

Tip: Use 'take advantage of' + a noun for a chance (take advantage of the offer); with a person, it sounds negative, so use it carefully.

Olena: Did you see the train tickets are half price this weekend?

Kofi: No! We should take advantage of that and finally visit your sister.

Olena: Good idea. I'll book two seats before the offer ends.

Kofi: Great. Can we leave early on Saturday? The mornings are quieter.

Olena: Sure. I'll find a train that leaves around eight.

45. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'take advantage of' mean?

- ○ A. Use a good chance while it is available
- ○ B. Take something that isn't yours
- ○ C. Pay more money to get a better seat
- ○ D. Treat someone unfairly to get what you want

46. Fill the gap

The hotel has a free breakfast, so make sure you _____ it before you check out.

47. Choose the best reply

Ken: *The gym is offering a free first month for new members.*

- ○ A. You should take advantage of that and try it out.
- ○ B. You should take advantage on that before it's finished.
- ○ C. You should take advantage of the gym and be unfair to it.

48. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you used a good chance to learn or try something new.

_____

_____

_____

up for grabs

Idiom · Level B2 · Casual

Available for anyone to take or win.

Tip: Use it for things anyone can claim, like jobs, prizes, seats or leftover food; it's usually 'be up for grabs' or 'is/are up for grabs', and it sounds odd for people or formal contracts.

Olena: Are you taking the desk by the window? You've been sitting there all week.

Kofi: No, it's not mine. Mei moved to the fourth floor yesterday.

Olena: So nobody has claimed it yet?

Kofi: Not that I know of. I think it's up for grabs until the manager decides.

Olena: Great, I'll move my laptop over now before someone else does.

Kofi: Good idea. That spot gets the best light.

49. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "up for grabs" mean?

- ○ A. Reserved for a person the manager has already chosen
- ○ B. Being fought over by several angry people
- ○ C. Available for anyone who wants to take it
- ○ D. Placed on a high shelf where it is hard to reach

50. Fill the gap

After the team moved offices, three monitors were left behind and are now _____ if you need one.

51. Choose the best reply

Amira: *Did anyone take the leftover pizza from the meeting?*

- ○ A. Not yet, so it's up for grabs. I'm going to grab you.
- ○ B. Yes, it was up for grabs, so I paid for it.
- ○ C. Not yet, so it's up for grabs. Help yourself.

52. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you saw something free or unclaimed and decided to take the opportunity.

Answer key

by all means

1. B. Yes, of course, go ahead
2. by all means
3. C. By all means, it's right there on the desk.
4. Example: Last month a colleague asked if she could use my notes for a presentation. I said, "By all means, they're on the shared drive." She was really grateful, and in the end we presented the project together.

clear up (weather)

5. C. The fog goes away and the weather gets brighter
6. cleared up
7. C. Don't worry, the forecast says it'll clear up by noon.
8. Example: Last summer we planned a beach day, but it rained heavily in the morning. We waited at a café for two hours, and luckily it cleared up around lunchtime, so we still got a few hours of sun.

come across

9. D. Found by chance
10. came across
11. A. I came across it in a second-hand shop last week.
12. Example: Last month I came across a small café while I was walking home a different way. The coffee was great and the staff were friendly, so now I go there almost every week.

cut down on

13. D. Use less of something
14. cut down on
15. A. Maybe you could cut down on it and cook at home more often.
16. Example: I've been trying to cut down on the time I spend on my phone in the evenings. I used to scroll for hours before bed, but now I set a timer for thirty minutes. It's not easy, but I'm sleeping better.

gathering dust

17. A. Nobody is using it any more
18. gathering dust
19. B. Not yet. Most of the boxes are still in the hall, gathering dust.
20. Example: I bought a bread machine a couple of years ago because I wanted to bake at home. It's been gathering dust in the kitchen cupboard ever since, because it's easier to buy bread from the shop on my way home from work.

get rid of

21. D. To stop using something because you do not want or need it any more
22. get rid of
23. C. I know. I really should get rid of all these old papers.
24. Example: Last month I got rid of my old laptop. It was so slow that it made working from home really frustrating. I gave it to a local repair shop, and now I have a lot more space on my desk.

keep (someone) posted

25. B. Send me updates as things change
26. keep you posted

27. C. Oh, I hope it goes smoothly. Keep me posted, okay?
28. Example: Last year I was waiting to hear about a job application, and it took almost three weeks. My parents kept asking, so I promised to keep them posted, and I sent a short message every time I heard anything. It made the waiting feel a bit less stressful.

on the receiving end of

29. C. The person who had to deal with someone's anger
30. on the receiving end of
31. C. Oh dear. It's not nice to be on the receiving end of a cold shoulder, even when you were polite.
32. Example: Last year I worked in a busy café, and one morning I was on the receiving end of a really angry complaint about a cold coffee. I stayed calm, apologised, and made a fresh one. In the end the customer smiled and even left a tip.

out of sight, out of mind

33. D. When something is not in front of you, you forget about it.
34. out of sight, out of mind
35. A. Out of sight, out of mind, right?
36. Example: When I need to concentrate, I put my phone in another room. It sounds simple, but it works for me because out of sight, out of mind. After an hour, I usually forget it's even there.

put (someone) off

37. D. Made me not want to join the gym
38. put me off
39. A. Not yet. The reviews about slow service put me off a bit.
40. Example: I used to love going to the cinema, but a few bad experiences with noisy audiences really put me off. Now I'd rather watch films at home, where I can pause them and relax. I might go again if I could pick a quiet showing.

to say nothing of

41. D. and also, which is an even bigger problem
42. to say nothing of
43. A. to say nothing of the long journey to work every day.
44. Example: Last year I took a night bus to visit a friend, and it was a disaster. The bus was two hours late and freezing cold, to say nothing of the seat that wouldn't stay upright. I arrived completely exhausted and slept most of the next day.

take advantage of

45. A. Use a good chance while it is available
46. take advantage of
47. A. You should take advantage of that and try it out.
48. Example: Last summer my company offered free language classes after work. I decided to take advantage of the offer and joined an evening Spanish course. It was hard at first, but I'm really glad I did it.

up for grabs

49. C. Available for anyone who wants to take it
50. up for grabs
51. C. Not yet, so it's up for grabs. Help yourself.
52. Example: Last year my company announced that a place on a training course in another city was still up for grabs. Nobody on my team had applied yet, so I wrote to my manager straight away. I got the place, and it helped me a lot at work.